

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

CFO-ORC FILE #

7-0 (A)

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X**Species:** Red-shouldered Hawk (*Buteo lineatus*)

Red 1/20/00 upl

Date: 1 January 2000**Number seen:** one**Sex:** unknown**Plumage:** Juvenal**Locality:** along S. Platte R., just upstream from York Ave.**Elevation:** about 5000'**Nearest town:** Commerce City**County:** Adams**Time observed:** about 12:45 - 12:55 PM MST**Duration of observation:** about 10 minutes

Description: After lunch, the party I was in on the Denver (Urban) CBC walked the path along the east side of the S. Platte River, heading upstream from York Ave. where that road crosses the river. Shortly after we started down the path (about 250 meters), we flushed a medium-sized raptor from a tree between the river and the path. The bird flew upstream fairly low over the river. It flew some 300 meters and perched in another tree on the opposite of the river, facing away from us. As soon as I got it in the bins on its upstream flight, I saw that the underwings were very pale and relatively unmarked. At that point, I thought that the bird was either a Broad-wing (BWA) or a Red-shoulder (RSA), either of which would be a spectacular bird for the count, but was strongly leaning toward RSA, as it looked too big for a BWA. As it flew up to the perch, I was concentrating on looking for translucent wing panels (typical of juvenile buteos), and only noticed some slightly paler area. After it perched, it was obvious that it had to be either a Red-tail (RTA) or a RSA. We walked quickly along the path to try to get a better look, particularly, since all we could see was the back. About half-way to the bird, we stopped and looked, and I could see that the wingtips fell well short of the tail tip (quite a bit due to the long tail the bird seemed to have), which in my mind identified the bird as a RSA. We finally got to a point where we could see the streaking on the underparts, thus eliminating RTA. Eventually, the bird turned on the perch, muted, then departed. On its flight away, the typical buffy-orange crescentic wing panels were readily seen.

The bird was generally brown above, with a brownish head. There was a faint, pale superciliary above the yellowish eyes. The cere was bluish-yellow and the bill was somewhat small for a buteo. The auriculars were grayish with some paler streaking. The bird had wide, but poorly-demarcated blackish malar stripes, that contrasted fairly strongly with the paler auriculars. The chin and throat were white, with a few dark streaks. The back and upper wing coverts were dark brown, with most feathers thinly-fringed with whitish. There was a little more white on the scapulars, but not as much as is typical for RTAs. The greater secondary coverts were grayish-brown, barred with blackish. The dark wingtips appeared to extend only just past half-way down the tail, thus falling much shorter than would the wingtips of either BWA or most RTAs. The underparts were white, with the chest, sides, and upper belly fairly heavily streaked with brown, with the streaking expanding to form a blob on each of many of the feathers. When the bird flew off the second time, I could easily see the broad, translucent, buffy-orange crescentic wing panels (crossing the outer five or six primaries).

The rest of the remiges were dark brown, banded with buff. The underwings were white with much dark spotting, but without any large, bold marks, such as the comma and patagial mark of RTHAs. In flight, the wings appeared rather long and parallel-sided with round wingtips. The legs were yellow.

Similar species eliminated: I make comparisons here only to juvenal-plumaged hawks, as adults of all similar species are readily eliminated by some aspect of plumage pattern, among other aspects. BWHA, the most similar in plumage pattern, is easily ruled out by size, wing length, wing panel shape and color, and wing shape. Most RTHAs are ruled out by plumage pattern, wing panel shape and color, wing length, and underwing pattern. Juvenal-plumaged rufous-morph RTHA can be entirely streaked below, thus being superficially similar to juvenal-plumaged RSHA. However, that form is much darker above and the streaking underneath is more chocolatey than that shown by the bird in question. They are also readily ruled out by other obvious characters, such as shape and wing patterns, both above and below. Cooper's Hawk and Northern Goshawk also have long tails but have relatively short wings, and no accipiters show translucent wing panels, particularly crescentic ones. Accipiters also do not show strong, dark malar stripes.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen in excess of 500 RSHAs, huge gobs of RTHAs (of an incredible variety of flavors), 1000s of BWHAs, and 100s to 1000s of almost all even remotely-similar species.

Light conditions: sky was mostly cloudy, with the sun relatively high (for the winter), and off to my left and/or behind me, but mostly behind the clouds

Optical equipment used: 7x42 Zeiss

Distance, and how estimated: estimated at about 25-30 meters at closest

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Dick Schottler, Warren Finch, and Bob Spencer

Other observers who saw the bird independently: Karleen Schofield among others

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph.

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: none

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:



Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Picadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 1, 10, and 17 January 2000 from notes written the evening of the 1st